

Introduction

Humans have been making art for more than 30,000 years. Even before civilizations became established, paintings and sculpture were created, often showing remarkably advanced and sophisticated artistic skills. As societies evolved, materials, processes and techniques developed, and the art that was produced changed to suit new, changing lifestyles.

Over the centuries, art has been made by almost all societies. For ease of understanding, much of it is grouped into movements, schools, periods and styles, often retrospectively by art historians, or sometimes by the artists themselves. But not all of it can be categorized. The history of art is never regular or predictable, and it constantly changes. Rarely created in an isolated moment of inspiration, it is nearly always an amalgam of circumstances and experiences, feelings and opinions, social, environmental or political situations, or developments in technology, beliefs, traditions or thinking. It is also always about endeavour, ability, process and product. Which is why it manifests in such a multitude of ways, and expresses anything from the universal to the commonplace.

Additionally, art has many functions. While much of it appears to have been created in imitation of the world, it is much more than that. It mirrors the times in which it has been made and, depending on the culture and location, can express and emphasize many different things, such as beauty, truth, death, order, immortality, power or harmony. As a form of communication or decoration, it can express philosophical points or religious beliefs, or it may simply entertain. Like another language, art becomes more fascinating when it is understood.

This book offers insights into a huge variety of art, from the earliest to the most recent. It's for anyone interested in art, from those who know a little, to those who know a lot. Roughly chronological, it considers many of the main developments in art throughout history and the world. In analyzing and appraising many inventions, ideas, materials and influences, backgrounds, skills, attitudes and approaches of groups of artists, skilled and talented individuals, and

even those who produced just one ground-breaking work of art, the book interprets and explains over 30,000 years of art in minutes.